

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

RED KNOT
Calidris canutus

Rcd 2/2/01 upl
 7-0 (A)

Location: Rocky Ford sewage lagoons; Rocky Ford; Otero County, Colorado

Date: September 3 and 10, 2000

I found these birds while birding along on the 3rd. They were seen by myself and other birders, at least through the 10th.

The Rocky Ford sewage lagoons are what they sound like. The pond where I found the Red Knots is the easternmost one. In September it was very low with shallow muddy edges. There were a variety of other shorebirds there, including yellowlegs, phalaropes, and Solitary and Semipalmated sandpipers. I observed the knots at a distance of about 50-75 yards with my Kowa TSN-4 scope. On the 3rd, observation was in full sun, from 11:05 - 11:30 a.m.

Description:

The two Red Knots foraged together in the shallow water. They were both juveniles. They were large, chunky calidrids, about 10-11" long. They were short, stocky and short-necked. They were slightly larger than Killdeer or Solitary Sandpiper. The body size was about like a Lesser Yellowlegs, but shorter-billed and shorter-legged. The legs were medium-short, rather thick, and blackish. The birds were sandy gray above, with thin pale edges to the scapulars, giving the birds a scaply appearance. Whitish supercilium. The sides of the breast had gray streaks and spots. The breast had a pale orangey-tan wash. The bill was thick, medium-long, nearly straight, with a thick base and a thin tapered tip.

Similar Species:

Plovers are more erect, larger-eyed, smaller-billed and do not feed by probing. Yellowlegs, Wilson's Phalarope, dowitchers, Curlew and Stilt sandpipers have white rump (and other problems). Other peeps too small and small-billed. Pectoral Sandpiper has brownish, not grayish, tones and distinct streaking on chest. Ruff has white on rump. Upland and Buff-breasted sandpipers much buffier, longer-necked, bigger-eyed and lack white wing stripe. Phalaropes too small, have smaller bills, blacker legs and do not feed by probing.

Experience with Species:

I have seen all mentioned shorebirds. I have seen quite a few breeding and winter plumaged Red Knots in Texas (and Colorado).

This report is prepared from notes made during observation.

Mark Janos
 10 Sedum Ct.
 Pueblo, CO 81001

markjanos